Presentation Rubric

Digitalist Papers Essays — How Your Presentation Will Be Scored

ECON 470 — Microeconomics of Artificial Intelligence

Spring 2026

What this rubric is for

This is the scoring sheet Professor Zambrano will use to grade your presentation and the discussion you lead. You are getting it *before* you prepare so you know exactly what to aim for. Five criteria, each scored on a four-point scale, with descriptive anchors so there are no surprises.

Scores are assigned at the **team level** — both teammates receive the same grade.

The five criteria

Criterion	Weight
1. Framing — stating the question the essay is trying to answer	15%
2. Argument — accurate, clear reconstruction of the author's logic	25%
3. Course Connection — use of Gans concepts to illuminate the essay	20%
4. Critique — your team's judgment about the argument	25%
5. Discussion Leadership — quality of the 10-minute discussion you run	15%

The weighting is deliberate. Argument, Course Connection, and Critique together account for 70% of the grade. That is because this course is about *thinking with the tools of economics* — we care more about whether you used the framework to say something real than about whether your delivery was smooth.

The scoring scale

Each criterion is scored on a four-point scale:

- **4 — Exemplary.** Work a professional economist would recognize as serious.
- **3 — Proficient.** Meets the standard expected of an advanced undergraduate in this course.
- **2 — Developing.** Partial success; key pieces are missing or underdeveloped.
- **1 — Emerging.** Attempted but not yet at course level.

There is no middle score. You are being asked to commit, as a presenter, and the rubric commits back.

Detailed anchors

1. Framing (15%)

Can the audience tell, from the opening of your talk, what question the essay is trying to answer?

- **4 — Exemplary.** The question is stated in one crisp sentence at the top. It is specific enough that a listener could tell whether the author succeeded. The stakes of the question are made clear.
- **3 — Proficient.** The question is stated clearly and early. Its importance is noted, even if briefly.
- **2 — Developing.** A question is mentioned, but it is too broad ("AI and the economy"), buried several minutes into the talk, or stated as a topic rather than a question.
- **1 — Emerging.** No clear question is stated; the audience has to infer what the essay is about.

2. Argument (25%)

Did you reconstruct the author's logic accurately, and in a way the audience could follow?

- **4 — Exemplary.** The author's argument is laid out as a clear sequence of steps, each motivated by the last. Key moves (a model, a data pattern, a historical analogy) are explained in enough depth that the audience understands *why* they matter. No step is skipped or mischaracterized.
- **3 — Proficient.** The main steps of the argument are present and accurate. The audience can follow along. Minor pieces may be compressed or skimmed.
- **2 — Developing.** The argument is summarized at a high level but key steps are missing, out of order, or stated without explanation. Or the argument is reported accurately but at such length that the through-line is lost.
- **1 — Emerging.** The argument is misrepresented, or reduced to a list of conclusions without the reasoning that produced them.

3. Course Connection (20%)

Did you use at least one Gans concept to illuminate the essay, and did it fit?

- **4 — Exemplary.** A Gans concept (value of prediction, rules vs. decisions, insurance vs. protection, biased signals, asymmetric stakes, etc.) is used to clarify or pressure-test the author's argument in a way that genuinely adds something. The concept is applied correctly and in the author's own terms, not just name-dropped.
- **3 — Proficient.** A Gans concept is used, correctly, to connect the essay to material from the course. The connection is accurate even if the analytical payoff is modest.
- **2 — Developing.** A concept is mentioned but applied loosely or incorrectly, or the connection feels forced.
- **1 — Emerging.** No course concept is used, or the concept used is misidentified or misunderstood.

4. Critique (25%)

Does your team have a view about the argument, and can you defend it?

- **4 — Exemplary.** You identify a specific assumption, step, or claim you are skeptical of, explain *why* in precise terms, and defend your critique against an obvious counterargument. Or — equally valid — you identify a part of the argument that is stronger than readers tend to credit, and explain why. The critique reflects independent thinking.
- **3 — Proficient.** A specific part of the argument is questioned or endorsed, with a clear reason. The critique is defensible and shows engagement with the essay.
- **2 — Developing.** A critique is offered but stays at a general level ("I'm not sure the author is right about X"), without a specific target or reasoning.
- **1 — Emerging.** The presentation summarizes the essay and stops. No view is offered, or the "critique" repeats what the author already said.

5. Discussion Leadership (15%)

Did the ten-minute discussion generate good classroom conversation?

- **4 — Exemplary.** Your discussion questions are specific, open-ended, and rooted in the essay. You call on classmates, build on their comments, and push the discussion somewhere the class would not have gone on its own.
- **3 — Proficient.** Questions are well-constructed and generate discussion. You manage the conversation competently and make space for multiple voices.
- **2 — Developing.** Questions are too broad, too narrow, or answerable without having read the essay. Or the questions are fine but the discussion stalls and is not recovered.
- **1 — Emerging.** No real questions are posed; the "discussion" is a Q&A where you answer whatever classmates ask.

What is *not* on this rubric (and why)

Delivery polish, slide design, and memorization are not separate criteria. This is intentional.

The course asks you to present without slides and without reading (see the *Presentation Delivery* handout). That format removes the design dimension from the grade. Delivery quality enters this rubric implicitly through *Argument* — if your delivery is so rough that the audience cannot follow the argument, you lose points on Argument, not on a separate delivery row. If your delivery is nervous but the argument comes through, you are not penalized.

This reflects current pedagogical practice: grade the thinking and the communication of that thinking, not the performance.

A note on intellectual risk

The rubric rewards teams who take positions. A presentation that ends with *"and so the author concludes X"* will score in the 2 range on Critique regardless of how well the first four minutes went. A presentation that ends with *"we think the author's argument breaks down at step 3, here is why, and here is what we would propose instead"* is where the Exemplary scores live.

Taking an intellectual position is a skill, and the course grades it as one. Push back where you can defend it. If you end up agreeing with the author, say *why*, on your own terms.

Scoring sheet

This is what Professor Zambrano will fill in during your talk. Space is intentionally included for comments on each criterion so you get actionable feedback, not just a number.

Team members: _____

Essay: _____

Date: _____

Criterion	Score (1–4)	Notes
1. Framing (×15%)		
2. Argument (×25%)		
3. Course Connection (×20%)		
4. Critique (×25%)		
5. Discussion Leadership (×15%)		

Weighted total: _____ / 4.0

What went well:

What to work on for future presentations: